

Moments Frozen in Time

Browsing through old photo albums of my family always fascinated me. Looking at pictures of my parents when they were my age, or even images of me as a baby celebrating tiny milestones, is like a trip down memory lane. One day, while cleaning out a very cluttered closet in my house, I stumbled upon a small cardboard box among shelves of old, weathered magazines and miscellaneous household items. Curiously, I find myself foraging through the wilderness of this box. Amidst the collection of rather ancient cell phones, wires, and a SD-card reader, I discover a black, zippered pouch. After blowing off the many layers of dust, I open it, my hands trembling with anticipation as to what could be inside. Within the pouch, I find a camera. A digital camera, about the size of my hands, with a sleek, glossy red exterior and the 'Polaroid' logo engraved on the front in a sans-serif font. Holding the camera in the palm of my hands suddenly evokes a flood of memories and emotions in my mind.

Being more than a piece of technology, this camera was a part of my life even way before I was born. I turned it on after replacing the batteries, and accustomed myself to the myriad of buttons and functions embedded next to the matte screen. Surely, it could not hold a candle to technology in today's ever-changing world. But the fact that it was functional despite its low battery life and sometimes fuzzy resolution, was a true testament to the memories it has captured, the moments it has frozen in time. Browsing through this digital photo album was like being able to time travel into the past. The lens, a portal to my parents' generation. Every press of the silver 'next' button is like flipping through a story book of experiences, those that feel familiar, yet distant at the same time. As I flipped through the pictures, I saw so many of my mother; young

and ethereal, beaming in the courtyard of my grandparents' house in front of her new motorcycle; giving a speech at her university; posing with her sisters on the roof of their house, next to the same pots of vivid marigolds and against the same view of the beige and grey town against the radiant afternoon sunshine that I can never miss everytime I visit India. Then I saw portraits of my parents at their wedding, how the week-long festivities brought everyone in my family together, capturing moments of their youth. I felt like I was transported into another world, viewing an insight into my parents' lives prior to immigrating to Canada.

As the camera continues its journey through different walks of life, it transitions to me. Snapshots of me as a newborn, the date 2006/15/02 and time 8:37 AM occupying the bottom left corner of a photo of me swaddled in a white linen from the hospital, held by my grandpa. Or another one of my mother holding me up front, as if she's showing me to the world while I'm wearing a fuschia coloured sweater that she knit for me herself. Some of the photos felt more familiar than others, like the one where I'm coloring with crayons, and I could smell the earthy smell of the wax that evokes nostalgia and everything about childhood through the photo. Or pictures of the park we would go to every evening in the summer when I was seven, which had a fountain filled with pennies and childhood wishes; I could practically hear the splashing and rippling sounds of the water through the image. I even stumbled upon a picture of my mom, dad, and four-year old me in an airplane, flying to our first trip to India upon immigrating here. So many experiences that would have otherwise vanished into the depths of the atmosphere, but now they were safely frozen in the lens of the camera, as if it were a refuge from the world, or a means of preservation. While these photos were low-definition, they showcased a childhood

enriched with love, parts of us that seemingly become distant, preserved from the endless ticking of time.

Today, this keepsake of memories sits proudly on a shelf in my room. It doesn't only display pictures, but communicates moments of laughter, joy, and the process of growing up, still a significant component of my life. A companion when I travel, it teaches me to enjoy the little things in life, and find beauty in the mundane; capturing the sunlight as it softens the edges of my room; the tall, technicolor trees of autumn; or the pristine blanket formed by the snow as it falls from the sky. My camera remains to be a timeless possession, and every click of the shutter symbolizes moments frozen in time.